‘mental maps’ are to understanding the creation of British foreign policy. Taking this idea further, it starts to become apparent that perhaps part of the reason there has always been such debate around the Great Game is that the parameters of the definition have been wrong. Hitherto writers have been too busy discussing what British and Russian officials were doing, not what they were thinking. Treaties and events were simply the manifestations of a certain mentality that was determined to view the other imperial power as a hostile rival. And, if the Great Game only really existed as a particular way of thinking (a ‘Great Game mentality’), then it could not end simply with the signing of an agreement.[61] Only if the 1907 convention had represented a true change of heart between the ruling elite of each country, could it have been said to mark the end of the Great Game era. But as an artificial construct, created by expediency, it is unsurprising that the agreement only had a limited effect on Anglo-Russian relations after 1907.

Perhaps one way of thinking about the Great Game mentality is by looking at the Cold War. One cannot define this era of American-Soviet competition by simply studying the Cuban Missile Crisis, for example. Instead, only by comprehending the intangible forces of fear, hostility, distrust and paranoia that characterised US and Soviet interaction after 1945 can the Cold War be fully understood. In fact, one could even argue that the Great Game was the precursor to the Cold War. For, if the argument is accepted that the Great Game existed essentially as a certain way of thinking, and that wars and treaties do not serve to define its boundaries, then it becomes clear how the Game could have reverberations throughout the twentieth century.[62] If the analogy with the Cold War is extended, one can even see how the 1907 convention was arguably the equivalent of Détente – a short respite from the otherwise largely relentless endeavours of each power to gain hegemony in South Asia at the expense of the other.

The presumption has always been that in 1917 with a change of government in Moscow came the end of the Great Game. Yet, it is already apparent that if British officials had been used to following a Great Game way of thinking for decades prior to 1917, the advent of the Bolshevik regime was not going to be enough to simply erase that mental process. Men such as Curzon resolutely believed that the British Empire was involved in a battle for supremacy in Asia with a real and committed opponent, a view which